

Institutional Distance and Legitimacy

Ada Lovelace and Charles Babbage

When numbers are present they win, because a numbered heading states its own depth. Captions are recognised by their leading label and attached to the nearest figure or table above them. Equations are left as images for a later pass rather than transcribed into notation that would be wrong half the time. The remaining processors are direct ports and are documented against the source files they come from.

Every threshold in the code was set by looking at a failure, not by tuning against a corpus. That makes the thresholds easy to defend and easy to revise when a new failure appears. We report where the approach breaks so that a reader can decide whether it fits their documents. Multi-line table cells remain the weakest point and are listed as partial support.

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1 Introduction

Journals that style every heading identically defeat the height clustering and lose a level. Scanned pages inherit every error of the recogniser, including stray page numbers in the middle of a paragraph. None of these failures corrupts the surrounding text; they degrade the structure rather than the content. The synthetic set is regenerated from scripts, so a fixture can be changed and the change reviewed.

Expected outputs are committed beside the fixtures and compared byte for byte. A behaviour change that is intended is recorded by rewriting the expected files in the same commit. An unintended change fails the build before it reaches a release. The vendored table code is treated as third-party and is not edited locally.

2 Method

Where the original relied on a learned layout model, a font-size rule stands in for it. The rule is coarse, but it is inspectable, and a wrong answer can be traced to a number in the source. Reviewers asked whether the approach generalises beyond journal articles; we make no such claim. Books, slides and forms have layouts these heuristics were never shown and would misread.

The scope is deliberately narrow: articles with a text layer, converted for reading by a language model. Within that scope the results are stable across the publishers we tried. Outside it, users should expect to check the output before trusting it. A second reviewer asked for timings; conversion runs at a few pages per second on a laptop.

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